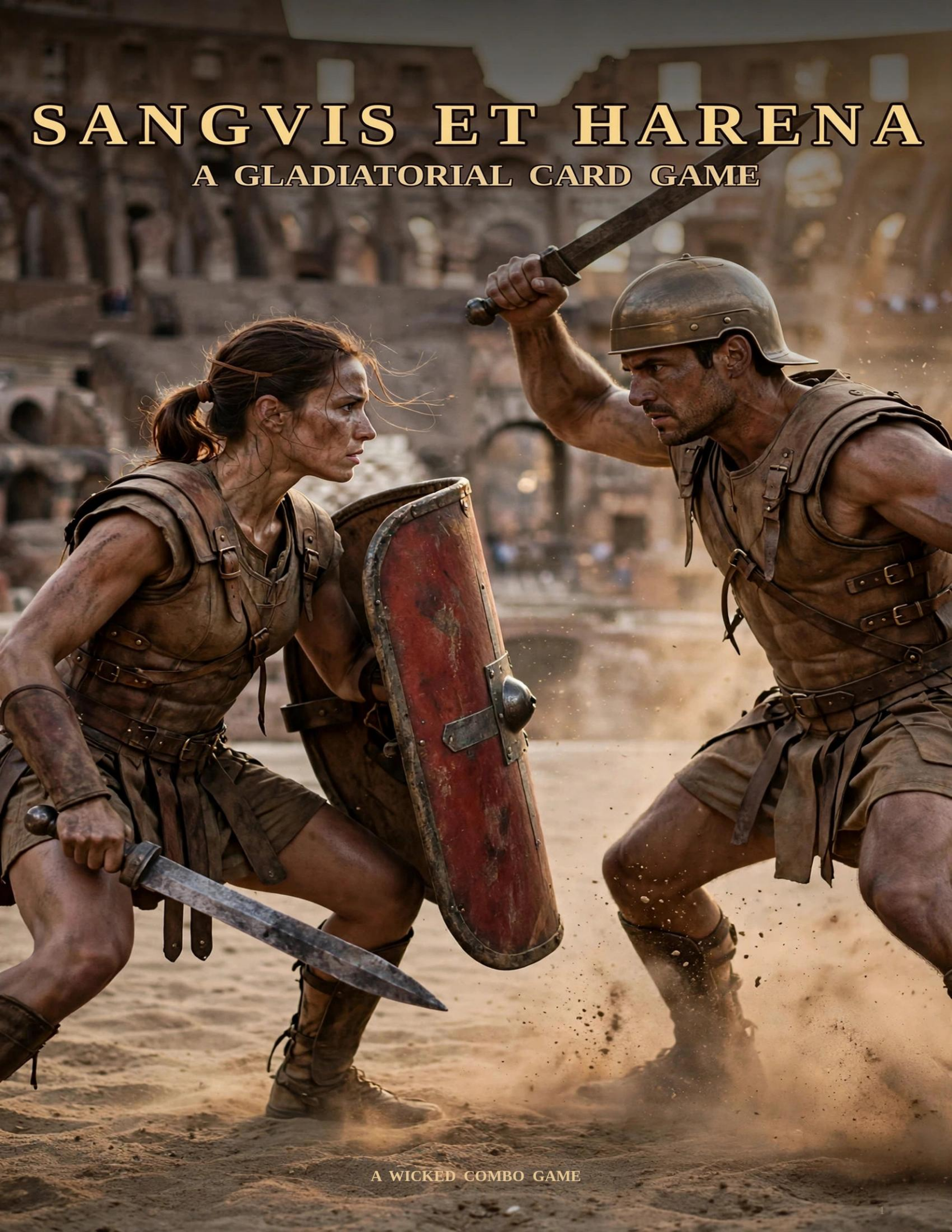
SANGVIS ET HARENA

A GLADIATORIAL CARD GAME



A WICKED COMBO GAME

Welcome to the Arena

Sanguis et Harena — "blood and sand" — drops you into the gladiatorial arenas of ancient Rome. You are a champion fighter. Win the crowd. Stay alive.

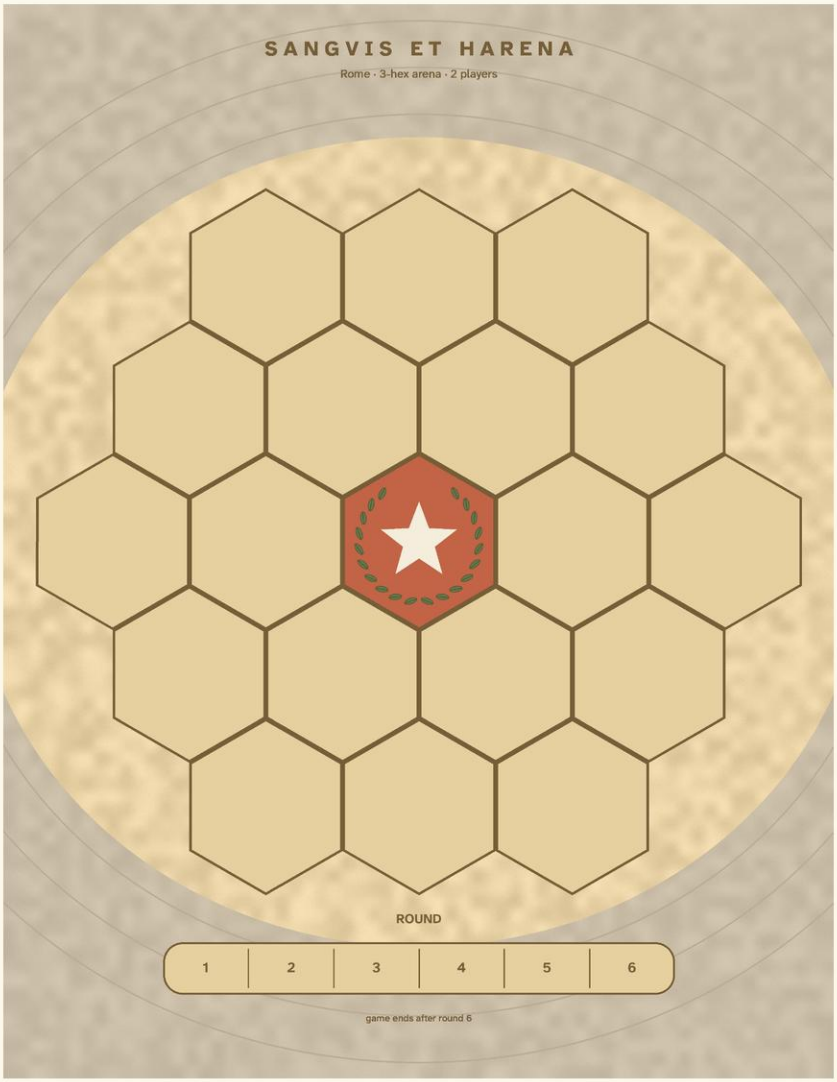
If you've played Wingspan, Terraforming Mars, or any modern board game, you'll pick this up fast. The rules take five minutes to learn. Every fight is different.

What You Need

- One 46-card deck per player: 23 action cards, 9 gear cards, 4 champion cards, 10 player aid cards
- The arena board (pick the size for your player count)
- Two player mats (one per player)
- Tokens for water, blood, and glory — coins or beads
- A figure or meeple per fighter to mark your position. We don't provide these — use a miniature, a wooden meeple, even a coin.

New to the game?

Play the basic game first (pages 3–7). The advanced rules on pages 8–10 add facing and weapon arcs for deeper tactics — but the basic game is complete on its own.



The 2-player arena — larger arenas for 3–6 players included

Goal & Setup

The Goal

Entertain the crowd. After 6 rounds, the fighter with the most glory wins.

If a fighter's blood hits zero, they're eliminated — unless they still have their second wind (once per bout, lethal damage leaves you at half your maximum blood instead). Last one standing wins immediately.

Setup

- Each player takes their own 46-card deck. Choose your champion from your 4 champion cards (both players may pick the same champion).
- Set water, blood, and glory tokens to your champion's starting values.
- Choose your loadout (see below): weapons, shields, and armor for your hands, arms, and head.
- Place fighters on opposite sides of the arena.
- Pick a starting player randomly — they get the first player marker.

Your Loadout

Pick weapons and shields for your hands, armor for your arms and head. Weapons determine how much blood your attacks spill. Armor costs water every round — shed it between rounds if you're running dry.

- Weapons: Gladius, Sica, Trident, Net
- Shields: Scutum, Parma
- Armor: Manica (arm), Galea (heavy helm), Cassis (light helm)



Rufus, ready for the arena: Gladius in the right hand, Scutum in the left

How a Round Works

Each round has 6 seconds. Every second follows five steps:

> **CHOOSE → SHOW → ACT → BURN → REPEAT**
>
> This is the heartbeat of the game. You'll do this 36 times per game — it becomes second nature fast.

CHOOSE

Secretly pick one card from your hand. Hold it face-down. Say "ready" when everyone has chosen.

SHOW

Everyone reveals at once. Place your card on the burn-down track in the column matching its heat: 1, 2, or 3 fire icons.

ACT

In player order (starting with the first player), each player takes their turn. Every card on your burn-down track is active — take their actions in any order, and skip any you don't want.

If you're at the arena edge, you can spend the second to rally (gain water equal to your champion's rally value, at most once per round) or change your loadout instead of acting.

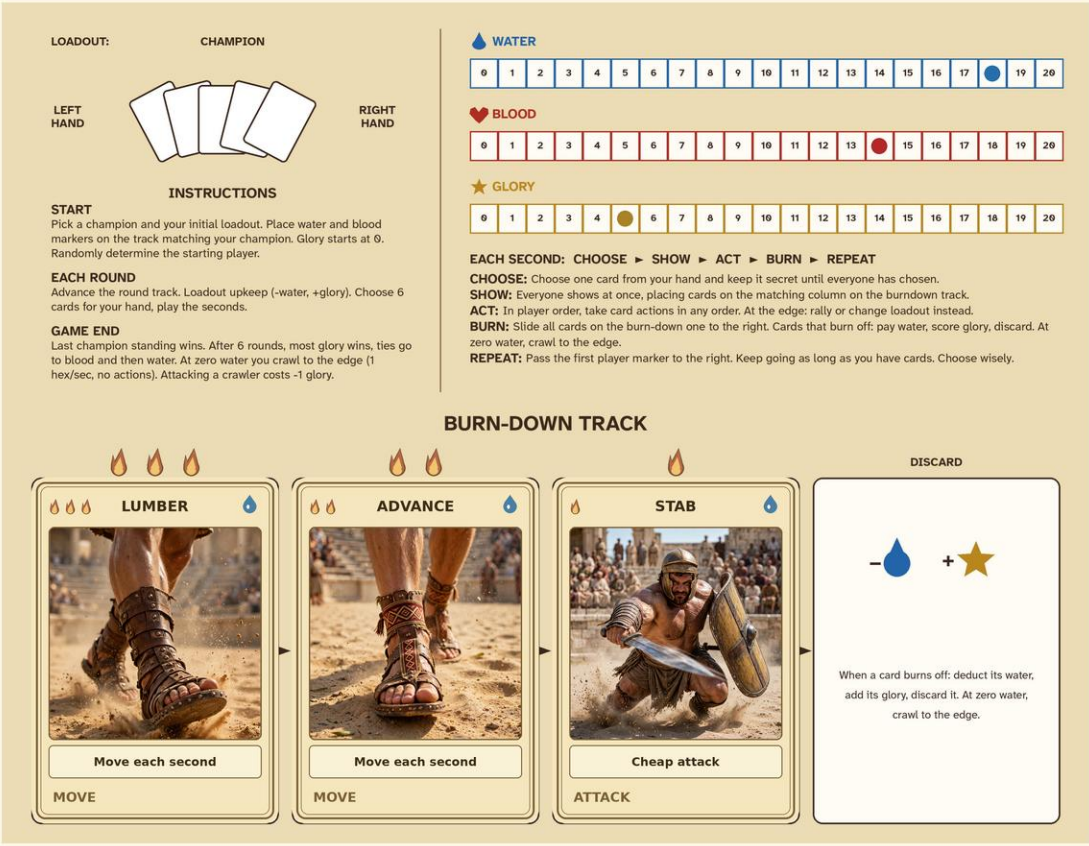
BURN

Slide all cards on the track one step right. Cards that fall off: pay their water cost, discard them. (Glory scores on success, not at burn-off.)

Then check your water. If it's at zero, you start crawling — see page 6.

REPEAT

Pass the first player marker right. Next second!



Your mat mid-round: cards burning down, markers on the tracks

The Cards

Five types. Here's what they do:

Movement

Quick Step, Retreat, Sidestep, Advance, Lumber, Circle, Wheel. Get around the arena. Some are quick, some cover ground, some spin you around.

Attacks

Stab, Sottano, Fendente, Redoppio. Each pairs with your weapon. Your weapon — not the card — determines how much blood you spill.

Defense

Duck, Dodge, Jump, Parry. Avoid or block attacks. Duck evades high attacks. Jump evades low attacks.

You can also block with gear. When you're attacked, you may block with a shield or armor piece — your choice, each attack. Each blocked attack puts 1 dent on that gear (scutum 4, parma 2, manica 3, galea 4, cassis 3 dents). Fully-dented gear falls off — remove it from your loadout. Net attacks can be blocked like any other attack.

Flourishes

Spinta, Molinello, Salute, Kip-Up. Showy moves that earn glory. Kip-Up also pops you back up when you're prone.

Combos

Lunge (move then attack), Ritirata (attack then move), Riposte (defend then attack), Kron (defend with style). Two actions, one card.



Top row: one of each type. Bottom row: more of the deck

Water, Glory & Prone

Water — Your Fuel

Every card costs water (droplets, top-right corner). You pay when the card burns off — not when you play it.

Crawling — Out of Water

When BURN leaves your water at zero, you start crawling. You're exhausted, dragging yourself toward the edge for relief.

- While crawling, the only action you can take is moving one hex per second toward the edge (you still play one card each second).
- At the edge, rally: spend one second to gain water equal to your champion's rally value. Rally at most once per round — a crawling fighter may always rally.
- You can also change your loadout at the edge — that costs one second too.
- Attacking a crawler costs the attacker 1 glory. The crowd hates it.

Glory — Your Score

Glory is stars (bottom-right corner) — every starred card is worth 1 star. You score it when the card succeeds: an attack card scores when one of its attacks lands, a defense card scores each time it stops an attack, a flourish scores when you play it (not when played face-down while crawling). Burn-off pays water only. Most glory after 6 rounds wins.

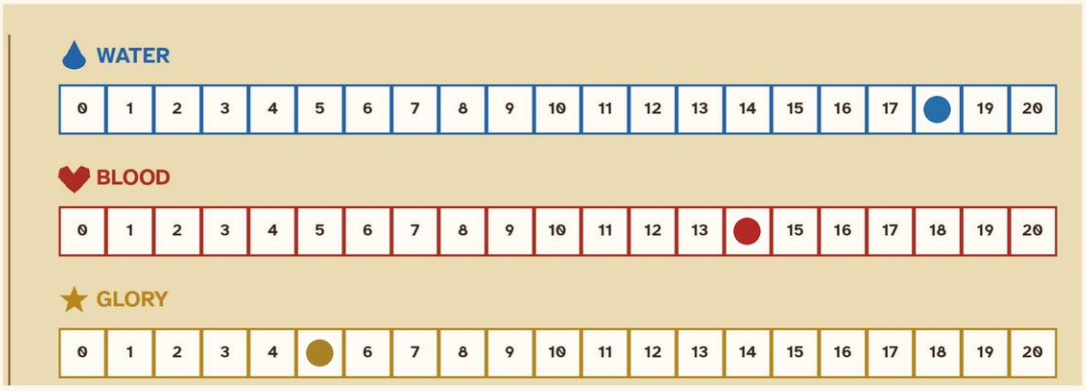
Going Prone

Take 3+ blood in one second and you're knocked flat. You waste your next second standing up — no actions. Kip-Up negates prone instantly.

While prone, you may raise a finger (“ad digitum”) to concede the match — the ancient signal of surrender.

Kip-Up cancels prone!

Knocked flat? Play Kip-Up and snap straight back to standing — no wasted second. It's the only card that skips the stand-up, and it earns glory too.





Track your water, blood, and glory — and keep a Kip-Up handy

The Champions

Four fighters. Four styles. Each has a special ability usable once per round.

Rufus the Ox

The brute. Once per round: Stab as an additional action.

Vela the Eel

The swift. Once per round: Move as an additional action.

Cassius the Peacock

The showman. Once per round: an additional flourish glory.

Drusa the Wall

The veteran. Once per round: Parry as an additional action.



Rufus, Drusa, Cassius, Vela — pick your champion

Advanced Rules

You've got the basics. These optional rules add tactical depth. The basic game is complete without them.

Facing

In the advanced game, your fighter has a facing — the direction they're looking. It matters for attacks and defenses.

Turn 60° for free at any time during your turn. The Wheel card turns you 120°.

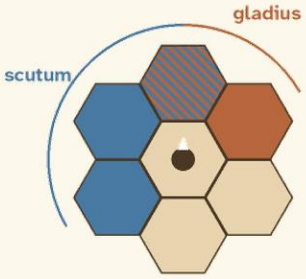
Attack & Defense Arcs

Your weapon hits the hex directly ahead plus the hex on its hand's side. Your shield covers the hexes on its hand's side. The hexes behind you are always exposed.

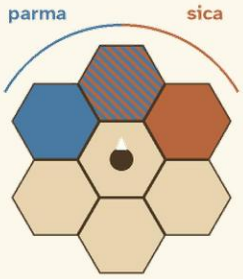


Example Loadouts

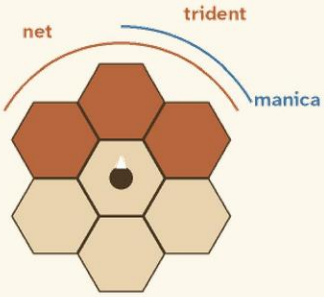
Four historical loadouts with their weapon and shield arcs. Red hits, blue blocks, stripes where both cover.



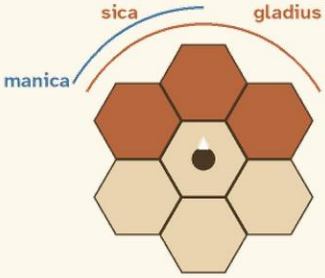














Advanced Reference

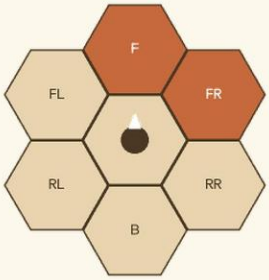
Facing, weapon arcs, and shield arcs. Add one or more of these to deepen the game.

1 — FACING

Your fighter has a direction. Turn 60° as a free action at any time during your own action turn.

2 — WEAPON ARCS

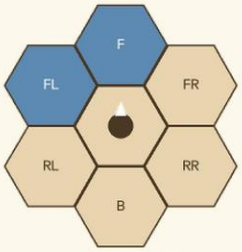
A weapon hits the forward hex and the hex on its hand's side (60°). Arcs are measured from the hex center, so the forward hex is always in arc.



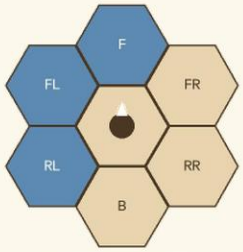
Right-hand weapon hits F + FR

3 — SHIELD ARCS

Parma (60°): the forward hex + the hex on its hand's side.
Scutum (120°): forward + its side + the rear hex on its side.
Manica (60°): the sword arm's arc. Helms: every direction (360°).



Left-hand parma (60°)



Left-hand scutum (120°)

Appendix: What's in a Name

Every name in this game comes from real history — Roman arms and armor, the Italian fencing masters, and Latin itself. Here's where they come from.

The Title

- Sanguis et Harena (SAHN-gwis et hah-REH-nah) — "blood and sand." Harena is Latin for sand: the sand strewn across the arena floor to soak up blood. Arena itself comes from harena.

The Steel — Roman Weapons

- Gladius (GLAH-dee-us) — the short sword of the Roman legionary, built for the thrust in close ranks.
- Sica (SEE-kah) — the curved blade of Thrace and Dacia, carried in the arena by the thraex gladiator.
- Trident & Net — the signature kit of the retiarius, the "net-man," who fought with trident (fuscina) and weighted net (rete), no helmet, no shield.

The Defense — Roman Armor

- Scutum (SKOO-tum) — the great curved rectangular shield of the legions.
- Parma (PAHR-mah) — the small round shield of light troops — and of the thraex in the arena.
- Manica (mah-NEE-kah) — the segmented arm guard. Gladiators wore it on the sword arm; the retiarius wore it on the exposed left.
- Galea (gah-LAY-ah) & Cassis (KAS-sis) — Latin for helmet, heavy and light. The cassis was the plain bronze cap with no crest — exactly what Rufus wears on his cards.

The Blows — the Fencing Masters

Our attack names come from the Italian masters — Fiore dei Liberi (c. 1409) and Filippo Vadi (c. 1482), whose fight-books catalogued the true cuts of the sword:

- Fendente (fen-DEN-tay) — the descending cut. Vadi's own verse: "We are the fendenti, the downward cuts, that start fights."
- Sottano (sot-TAH-noh) — the rising cut, thrown upward from below. One of Fiore's seven true blows.
- Redoppio (reh-DOH-pyoh) — the redoubled cut: strike, then strike again in the same breath. Named in the Bolognese tradition.
- Molinello (moh-lee-NEL-loh) — "the little mill." A wheeling circular cut, described by the Bolognese masters and given its own chapter by Alfieri (1653).
- Ritirata (ree-tee-RAH-tah) — the retreat: strike, then withdraw in good order. A formal term of the Italian salle.
- Salute (sah-LOO-tay) — the fencer's salute to opponent and crowd — which is exactly what it earns you: glory.

The Champions — Roman Names

- Rufus (ROO-fus) — a common Roman cognomen meaning "red-haired." Half the legions seemed to have one.
- Cassius (KAS-ee-us) — one of the great Roman gentes. A conspirator's name for a showman.
- Drusa (DROO-sah) — the feminine form of Drusus, a proud Roman cognomen borne by generals and emperors' kin.
- Vela (VEH-lah) — Latin for "sails." She moves like a reed in the wind; the name is our invention, but the Latin is real.

From Other Schools

Two cards honor fencing traditions beyond Italy:

- Kron (krohn) — German for "crown." The crown guard of the Liechtenauer tradition.
- Riposte (rih-POHST) — the French school's answer: the return thrust delivered in the same breath as the parry.

Appendix: Sequence of Play

The complete game, start to finish. This mirrors the player aid cards.

Setup

- Each player takes a 46-card deck: 23 action cards, 9 gear cards, 4 champion cards, 10 player aid cards.
- Pick your champion. Both players may pick the same one.
- Assign your loadout: weapons and shields for your hands, armor for your arms and head. Place the arena and round tracker.

Each Round

- 1. Advance the round track.
- 2. Cards on your burn-down track stay there.
- 3. If your deck has fewer than 6 cards, shuffle your discard pile back into it.
- 4. Choose 6 cards from your deck to build a fresh hand (planning).
- 5. Loadout upkeep: pay water equal to the water icons on your equipped gear. You may remove gear before paying.
- 6. Play the six seconds (see below).
- 7. End of round: +1 glory for holding the center hex, -1 glory for each fighter on an edge hex.
- 8. After round 6: most glory wins. If a fighter's blood hits zero, they're out — last one standing wins immediately.

Each Second: CHOOSE → SHOW → ACT → BURN → REPEAT

- CHOOSE — secretly pick a card from your hand, hold it in front of you and say "ready."
- SHOW — all players reveal simultaneously, placing cards on the burn-down track at matching heat.
- ACT — in player order: take your card's actions.
- BURN — slide all cards one slot right. Cards burning off: pay their water cost and discard them. (Glory scores on success.)
- REPEAT — pass the first player marker right. Next second.
- If you hit zero water, you are crawling (see Out of Water).

Taking Actions

- Move: shift one hex per second, up to your card's movement.
- Attack: pick a target in range and in your weapon's arc. Defender may block, dodge, or parry.
- Flourish: score 1 glory when you play it. (No glory when played face-down while crawling.)
- Instant cards resolve immediately and don't take a second.

Attack Resolution

- 1. Attacker declares target and weapon.
- 2. Defender declares defense (block with gear, Dodge, Parry, or take the hit).
- 3. Successful attacks spill the defender's blood based on the weapon. Gear takes dents when it blocks.
- 4. Spilling 3 or more blood in one second makes the defender prone.
- 5. Score glory for a successful attack.

Out of Water (Crawling)

- While crawling, the only action you can take is moving one hex per second toward the edge (you still play one card each second).
- Attacking a crawling fighter costs 1 glory.
- Reach the edge: rally (get water) costs one second.

FAQ

The questions everyone asks.

My cards are stacking up on the burn-down track. Do the new ones cover up the old ones?

No. Every card on the burn-down track is active. Take their actions in any order, and skip any you don't want. That's how you get wicked combos.

When do I pay water for a card?

When the card burns off (slides off the end of the track), not when you play it. Plan ahead.

Can I block with broken gear?

No. Broken gear gives no defense. Shed it between rounds if you're running dry on water.

Do I have to use my champion's special ability?

No. It's usable once per round, but you can save it or skip it.

What if I'm prone when my turn comes?

You waste the second standing up — no actions. Kip-Up negates prone instantly, no wasted second.

Can I turn to face a different direction mid-second?

In the advanced game, turn 60° for free at any time during your turn. The Wheel card turns you 120°.

Credits

SANGUIS ET HARENA

A Wicked Combo game.

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Game design and development by Mark Davis.

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Card art is AI-generated placeholder. Final art from human artists planned.

Thank you for bleeding on the sand with us.

In memory of Norm Davis, who gave us "The Norm Maneuver."

Special thanks to Paul Davis, for saying "I want to build a gladiator game."

Special thanks to Clan McFavis, for the early playtests.

SanguisEtHarena.com

WickedCombo.com